

From Local Resources to Growing Markets: The Entrepreneurial Journey of Shabnam

"When local resources are combined with determination, skills, and continuous learning, they can create sustainable livelihood opportunities for an entire community."

Background

For Shabnam being an entrepreneur started with an idea. That the things she had in her own community could be used to start a business that would last. Shabnam lives in Ser Jigas Panchayat, Rajgarh Block. She joined the Jagriti Self Help Group in 2021 because she wanted to learn new things and be able to take care of herself financially.

Shabnam was already doing a few things to earn money outside of farming before she got into food processing. She taught tailoring at a place where people could go to learn how to sew. She made things like bags out of jute, crochet items and other crafts using pine needles. She would make these things when people asked her to. Then she would sell them to people in her area. This helped her get better at making things and dealing with customers.

Shabnam wanted to find a way to use the natural things in her area to start a business that would also help other women earn money. This is what made her want to get into food processing. So in 2022 Shabnam started making squash, pickles and Sepu Badi. She thought this would be a way to use the things that grew in her area and help other women at the same time. Shabnam liked the idea of working with food and Buransh. She thought it could be a good business for her and the other women, in her community.

The Entrepreneurial Journey

The choice to begin a food processing business did not happen quickly. Before starting to make things Shabnam and other people in her Self Help Group went through hands-on training in making pickles and squashes. They also got money from a government program, which helped them buy tools like a scale, a mixer grinder, a packaging machine and the pots and pans needed for making things.

The money that was left was used to buy the things needed to make the products, which let the group start making things on a level.

At first they worked on making Buransh squash, a drink made from the flowers of the Rhododendron tree, which grows naturally in the nearby hills. Along with the squash they also made pickles and Sepu Badi using the things that were available in their area.

"हमने पहले प्रशिक्षण लिया फिर मशीनें खरीदीं और उसके बाद धीरे-धीरे उत्पादन शुरू किया। शुरुआत छोटे स्तर से हुई लेकिन हमारा उद्देश्य था कि स्थानीय संसाधनों से अच्छा व्यवसाय बनाया जाए।"

Instead of trying to sell a lot right away Shabnam first wanted to learn how to make the products, keep the quality good and feel sure, about the things they were making.

Business Growth

Shabnam was like other people who start their own businesses. She had a lot of problems when she was first starting out. Even though she made her products with care it was not easy to get people to trust her.

She and her team did not sell their products right away. Instead they tried them out themselves. Gave them to their friends and family. This helped them make their products better figure out what people liked and get their production process working smoothly.

At first Shabnam sold a bottle of squash for 130 to 150 rupees. She did this to get people to try her product. After people tried it and saw how good it was they started ordering more. Now she sells the product for 200 rupees a bottle. This shows that people trust her products.

One big reason of Shabnam's business is that she is very good at marketing. She tells people about her products by word of mouth. Uses social media like Instagram. She posts pictures and videos of how she makes her products and updates people when she has new batches ready. She also keeps track of every batch she makes. If someone has a problem she can find out which batch it was and check if other people had the same problem.

Shabnam says:

"मैं हर बैच का रिकॉर्ड रखती हूँ। अगर कोई ग्राहक कोई समस्या बताए, तो मैं तुरंत देख सकती हूँ कि वह किस लॉट का प्रोडक्ट था। इससे गुणवत्ता बनाए रखने में बहुत मदद मिलती है।"

Now people over the place are buying Shabnam's products. She sells them in villages and also in places like Bilaspur, Nahan and Chandigarh. People find out about her products from their friends from exhibitions and from media.

To make sure people feel safe buying her products Shabnam sells them under the name of her Self Help Group. She has all the certifications, like FSSAI and she labels and packages her products properly. She even puts the manufacturing details, expiry dates and everything, on the label.

Learning Through the IIT Delhi Training

Shabnam had already started her food processing business. She thinks that learning new things all the time is necessary for making her business bigger. She went to the Entrepreneurship Development Programme at IIT Delhi. It was really helpful. She got to know things that were not just about making products but about how to make her small business more organised and work well with customers.

She says:

"इस प्रशिक्षण से मुझे यह समझ आया कि व्यवसाय केवल उत्पाद बनाने तक सीमित नहीं है। अगर हमें आगे बढ़ना है, तो हमें अपने व्यवसाय को सही तरीके प्रबंधित करना और नए अवसरों को अपनाना भी सीखना होगा।"

One thing she found useful was learning about digital business tools. At the training she got to know about platforms like WhatsApp Business, Amazon, Meesho and other online marketplaces that can help business owners like Shabnam connect with customers from all over not just her local area.

The programme also taught her about financial management. She learned that keeping records can make running her business easier and help her keep track of things better. Shabnam also learned that making her business official is important. She got to know more about Udyam Registration and government support schemes and how making her business official can help her expand it in the future.

The training also showed her how important it is to have branding, packaging and product labelling to make customers trust her products. Even though Shabnam had already started labelling her products the programme taught her that professional packaging, clear product information and making her products look good are also necessary, for selling them in markets.

Applying the Learnings in the Business

The knowledge that Shabnam gained through the programme has encouraged her to start using new business practices in her enterprise. She wants to make the digital presence of her products stronger by using WhatsApp Business, social media platforms and online marketplaces in a way to connect with more customers. She also wants to keep digital records of production, sales, expenses and customer orders to make better business plans and decisions. She says, "Now my effort will be that I use methods better keep systematic records of my business and also reach my products further, from the local market." The training has also inspired her to keep making improvements to product packaging and branding so that

customers can quickly recognize the quality and real value of the products. She thinks that combining quality local products with good presentation will help the enterprise compete in bigger markets. Importantly the programme has made her more confident to think beyond selling at the district level. She now wants to spread the reach of the Self Help Groups products across Himachal Pradesh and slowly reach customers in other states.

"अब मेरा प्रयास रहेगा कि मैं डिजिटल माध्यमों का बेहतर उपयोग करूँ, अपने व्यवसाय का व्यवस्थित रिकॉर्ड रखूँ और अपने उत्पादों को स्थानीय बाज़ार से आगे भी पहुँचाऊँ।"

Looking Ahead

Shabnam thinks that the future of entrepreneurship is all about mixing old ways of doing things with new business ideas. She wants to keep adding products make it easier for people to buy and sell things and get more women involved in making food products that are worth more money.

For Shabnam the best part is not just that the business is growing but that the women in the group are becoming more confident by working together and learning new things all the time.

"हमारा उद्देश्य केवल उत्पाद बेचना नहीं है, बल्कि अपने क्षेत्र के स्थानीय उत्पादों को पहचान दिलाना और अधिक से अधिक महिलाओं को आत्मनिर्भर बनाना है।"

She believes that every time someone learns something new, it helps the business and every woman who can take care of herself financially makes the whole community stronger. Shabnam thinks that rural entrepreneurship like this is really important for women. Shabnam wants to see more women get involved in entrepreneurship and make a good life for themselves.